Lesson 39: Nouns

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 4: Words, Word Order and the Essay

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 16 Nouns.

In this lesson

You review the types of English nouns (proper and common, singular and plural, count and noncount) and learn seven rules for using them. You practise finding noun errors in sentences and paragraphs about food and nutrition. Noun errors ("informations", "two cup", "I eat apple") are very common in student writing, so this helps you edit your own academic work.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Tell proper nouns from common nouns and capitalize proper nouns.
- Spell the plural forms of regular and irregular nouns.
- Use count and noncount nouns with the right determiners, verbs and pronouns.
- Use nouns correctly after "one of", "each" and "every", and in number + noun adjectives.
- Find and correct noun errors in a paragraph.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
noun	a name of a person, place, thing or idea	scientist, Chicago, safety
proper noun	a specific name of a person, place or organization; it starts with a capital letter	Harper College
common noun	a general name; no capital letter	president, office
count noun	a noun you can count (1, 2, 3…); it has a singular and a plural form	one egg, three eggs
noncount noun	a noun you cannot count; it is always singular	water, information
determiner	a word before a noun: an article (a, an, the), a number, a possessive adjective (my, his) or a demonstrative adjective (this, that)	**This** label
nutrient-dense	full of nutrients	nutrient-dense foods and beverages

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
beverage	a drink	85% of our calories from nutrient-dense foods and beverages
garnish	food or drink decoration to increase flavor, color, etc.	garnish made of vegetables
rinse	wash lightly by pouring water over something	rinse the beans with water
vegetarian	a person who eats only vegetables	Nutrients for Vegetarians
fixture	something that is fixed in a place	a weekly fixture on my family's dinner table

Rules and explanations

Proper nouns and common nouns

- **Proper nouns** are specific names: Albert Einstein, Michigan Avenue, the Department of Agriculture. They start with a capital letter.
- **Common nouns** are general names: scientist, city, computer, safety. No capital letter (except at the start of a sentence).

Singular and plural: spelling

(Vowels are a, e, i, o, u. Consonants are all the other letters.)

The singular noun ends in	Plural	Examples
most letters	add -s	apple - apples, grape - grapes
ch, sh, x, s, ss, z	add -es	dish - dishes, box - boxes, bus - buses (but quiz - quizzes, ox - oxen)
vowel + y	add -s	day - days, key - keys
consonant + y	delete y, add -ies	family - families, strawberry - strawberries
vowel + o	add -s	radio - radios, zoo - zoos
consonant + o	add -es	hero - heroes, potato - potatoes (but piano - pianos, photo - photos)
f or fe	delete f or fe, add -ves	leaf - leaves, knife - knives, half - halves (but chef - chefs, roof - roofs, belief - beliefs)

- Irregular plurals: man - men, child - children, person - people, foot - feet, tooth - teeth, goose - geese, crisis - crises, analysis - analyses.
- The same form for one and many: sheep, deer, fish, shrimp. Always plural: glasses, scissors, jeans, pants.

Count and noncount nouns

- **Count nouns** can be counted: one brother, three eggs. Use the plural form for more than one.
- **Noncount nouns** cannot be counted or are too small to count. They are always singular: water, coffee, rice, salt; English, math; danger, love.
- To count a noncount noun, count a unit: a cup of fruit juice, two slices of bread, three pieces of new equipment.

Seven rules for using nouns

1. Do not put "a/an" or a number before a noncount noun, and do not add -s to it.
    - Wrong: The restaurant has installed three new equipments. Right: ... some new equipment / three pieces of new equipment.
2. Do not use "a/an" and -s on the same noun. Wrong: Many children eat an apples every day. Right: an apple / apples.
3. A singular count noun needs a determiner. Wrong: I eat apple every day. Right: I eat an apple (one apple) every day. Wrong: Please join discussion on healthy living. Right: our discussion / the discussion.
4. A singular count noun or a noncount noun takes a singular verb and pronoun; a plural noun takes a plural verb and pronoun.
    - "A medium tomato **has** about twenty-two calories ... **It** does not contain any cholesterol."
    - "Fresh tomatoes **are** on sale ... **They** taste great."
5. "one of" + plural noun + singular verb (the subject is "one"): "One of the nutrients from dairy **is** calcium."
6. A number + noun that works as an adjective (before another noun) stays singular, because English adjectives have no plural: a 3-credit-hour course, 9-year-old boys. Compare: a child nine years old.
7. "each" and "every" + singular count noun: "**Each glass** is filled with juice." "**Every guest** is having a fun time."

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Some English noncount nouns are plural words in Arabic (for example "information", "equipment" and "advice"), so learners write "informations" or "equipments". In English these nouns never take -s.
> - Arabic has no separate word for "a/an", and after numbers above ten Arabic uses a singular noun. In English a singular count noun needs a determiner ("an apple"), and every number above one takes a plural noun ("thirty minutes").

Practice

Exercise 1. Proper and common nouns. List the proper nouns and the common nouns in each sentence.

Look at the example in your lesson material first. (Its list of common nouns includes "recommendations", but that word is not in the example sentence: this is a mistake in the book.)

1. The Guidelines provide advice on what to eat more and what to eat less in order to stay healthy.
2. The Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2020-2025 offers recommendations for each life stage, from birth through older adulthood.
3. There are three key principles: choose mainly from the food with high nutrition, select a variety of choices from each of the five food groups, and pay attention to the portion size.
4. It is never too early or too late to improve dietary choices for a healthy lifestyle.

Exercise 2. Singular or plural? Choose the correct form for each blank.

Example: There are many ideas (idea, ideas) to keep us healthy in the Dietary Guidelines for Americans.

One (1) _____ (suggestion, suggestions) is to eat more (2) _____ (vegetable, vegetables). It is recommended that we eat two and a half (3) _____ (cup, cups) of vegetables a day. Unfortunately, many people in the U.S., including (4) _____ (adult, adults) and (5) _____ (child, children) do not eat enough vegetables. The Dietary Guidelines will help people follow a healthy (6) _____ (diet, diets).

Exercise 3. Count and noncount nouns. There is one error in the use of a count or noncount noun in each sentence about the Nutrition Facts label. Find the error and correct it.

Example: There is a lot of ~~advices~~ (advice) on leading a healthy life.

1. The Nutrition Facts label tells consumers a lot of informations about the food they are buying.
2. It lists how many servings there are in the package, how many calories each serving has, and how many gram of nutrients each serving contains.
3. In the label for frozen lasagna below, there are four serving in the package, and each serving equals 1 cup, with 280 calories.
4. Knowing how many servings we are eating is important. If we have 2 servings of lasagna for dinner, we will eat 2 cup, with 560 calories and 18 grams of fat!
5. We should always remember to add vegetables to the dinner plate: tomatoes, peppers, corns, and others.
6. Eating healthy seems like a lot of works, but it is worth our time and efforts.

Exercise 4. Nouns and determiners. There is one error in the use of a noun or its determiner in each sentence about healthy eating. Correct the noun or its determiner. Do not change anything else.

Example: ... drinking skim milk instead of whole milk might help us lose ~~an extra pounds~~ (extra pounds or an extra pound).

1. Although juice is a convenient source of vitamin, it is low in fiber.
2. It is better to have whole orange than a cup of orange juice.
3. One of the problem in the modern diet is having too much sodium.

4. When we eat cooked bean from a can, we should dump the sauce in the can and rinse the beans with water before eating them.
5. A five-courses meal may look delicious, but it almost always has too much fat, cholesterol, and sodium contents.
6. A two-years-old child should eat about three ounces of grains every day. A child nine years old should eat about five ounces.
7. If the children are nine year old, they should eat about five ounces of grains every day.
8. We should not forget to drink a water every day.
9. One of the best way for us to stay healthy is to watch what we eat and drink daily.
10. At last night's party, the hosts made sure that every dishes was hot and decorated with garnish made of vegetables.

Exercise 6. Edit a paragraph. In your lesson material, read "Nutrients for Vegetarians" (Exercise 6). Find and correct twelve more noun errors (not counting the example, nutrient → nutrients). In the book the nouns to check are underlined; if your printed copy does not show the lines, check every noun.

Exercise 7. Edit a paragraph. In your lesson material, read "With My Grandma in the Kitchen" (Exercise 7). Find and correct twelve more noun errors: four in each paragraph (the example in paragraph 1, dish → dishes, is not counted).

More practice: lesson material, Exercise 8 ("Baked Soy Ginger Salmon"). Your tutor can check it.

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to the Pretest and Exercise 8 in the lesson material. Explain each mistake with one of the seven noun rules."
- "Ask me what I eat on a normal day. Correct my plurals, count and noncount nouns, and determiners."
- "I will choose a saying about food from Exercise 5 in the lesson material and say for two minutes whether I agree and why. Then list my noun errors."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. Mark every noun error and tell me which rule it breaks."

Read aloud

The plural ending sounds /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/.

- One egg contains many nutrients /s/.
- Most people eat three meals /z/ a day, with a snack in between.
- Some sell computers /z/, and some sell groceries /z/.
- There are two slices /ɪz/ of bread in my lunch box.
- Each glass is filled with juice for children and wine for adults /s/.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 150 to 200 words (Exercise 11): What is your favorite food from your native country? What food group does it belong to? Why is it your favorite? Can you buy it where you live now? Include a short recipe if you can.

- Include a title, a topic sentence, three supporting points with details, and a concluding sentence.
- Use five or more plural nouns, two noncount nouns with a unit (a cup of rice), one "one of" + plural noun, and one "each" or "every" + singular noun.

Self-editing checklist:

- Proper nouns start with a capital letter.
- Plural nouns are spelled correctly (-s, -es, -ies, -ves, irregular).
- No noncount noun has "a/an", a number or -s.
- Every singular count noun has a determiner (a, an, the, my, this...).
- Verbs and pronouns agree with their nouns.
- "One of" + plural noun + singular verb; "each/every" + singular noun.
- Number + noun adjectives are singular: a 30-minute recipe.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2020-2025 (Exercise 9: choose a topic, list the nouns on its page, then free write for five minutes about what you learned): https://www.dietaryguidelines.gov/sites/default/files/2020-12/Dietary_Guidelines_for_Americans_2020-2025.pdf
- MyPlate Kitchen recipes (Exercise 10: write a short review of one recipe): https://www.myplate.gov/myplate-kitchen/recipes

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Proper: Guidelines (short for the Dietary Guidelines). Common: advice. ("Order" in "in order to" is part of a fixed phrase; you do not need to list it.)
2. Proper: Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2020-2025. Common: recommendations, life stage (life, stage), birth, adulthood.
3. Proper: none. Common: principles, food, nutrition, variety, choices, food groups (food, groups), attention, portion size (portion, size). ("Key" works as an adjective here: "main".)
4. Proper: none. Common: choices, lifestyle.

Exercise 2 (book)

1. suggestion 2. vegetables 3. cups 4. adults 5. children 6. diet

Exercise 3

1. informations → information
2. gram → grams
3. four serving → four servings
4. 2 cup → 2 cups
5. corns → corn
6. works → work

Exercise 4

1. vitamin → vitamins
2. whole orange → a whole orange (or: whole oranges)
3. the problem → the problems
4. cooked bean → cooked beans
5. five-courses → five-course ("sodium content" is also better than "sodium contents")
6. two-years-old → two-year-old ("a child nine years old" is correct)
7. nine year old → nine years old
8. a water → water
9. the best way → the best ways
10. every dishes → every dish

Exercise 6

1. dairy product → dairy products
2. calciums → calcium
3. another essential nutrients → another essential nutrient
4. spinaches → spinach

5. One of the iron source → One of the iron sources
6. nut → nuts
7. egg → eggs
8. a Vitamin B12 supplements → a Vitamin B12 supplement
9. a convenient and inexpensive sources → a convenient and inexpensive source (or: convenient and inexpensive sources)
10. Another essential nutrients → Another essential nutrient
11. for vegetarian who → for vegetarians who
12. sunlights → sunlight

Exercise 7

- Paragraph 1: fresh ingredient → fresh ingredients; a local grocery stores → a local grocery store (or: local grocery stores); homeworks → homework; my times → my time
- Paragraph 2: two apple → two apples; a small onions → a small onion (or: small onions); every broccoli florets → every broccoli floret; every raisins → every raisin
- Paragraph 3: each ingredients → each ingredient; the patiences → the patience; a huge spoons → a huge spoon (or: huge spoons); Many year → Many years

My notes